

SOUL: IMMORTALITY, REBIRTH AND LIBERATION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Jīvanmukti (2025 PYQ — Advaita): liberation WHILE living — the knower of Brahman is free now; the body continues by prārabdha karma (momentum of a spun wheel) until it drops (videhamukti). □ "Is immortality/rebirth necessary for a robust conception of liberation?" (2024): liberation presupposes bondage-across-lives (rebirth) and something that is liberated (the soul) — so substantial systems say yes; Buddhism shows liberation (nirvāṇa) is coherent even without an eternal soul. □□.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Jīvanmukti (2025 PYQ — Advaita): liberation WHILE living — the knower of Brahman is free now; the body continues by prārabdha karma (momentum of a spun wheel) until it drops (videhamukti). □ "Is immortality/rebirth necessary for a robust conception of liberation?" (2024): liberation presupposes bondage-across-lives (rebirth) and something that is liberated (the soul) — so substantial systems say yes; Buddhism shows liberation (nirvāṇa) is coherent even without an eternal soul. □□.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The magic sentence: "immortality of a substantial soul is sufficient for rebirth but not necessary; what rebirth needs is a continuity-bearer." Liberation = family-resemblance term.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

The Buddhist challenge (2022, 2024 PYQ): Buddhism denies a permanent soul (anātman/anattā) yet affirms rebirth — what is reborn is not a self but a causal continuum of momentary states (a flame passing from candle to candle; pratītyasamutpāda). → rebirth WITHOUT an immortal soul. □ "Is immortality a necessary condition for rebirth?" (2022, 2024, 2025): □□ Substantialist systems (Vedānta/Nyāya/Jain): YES — a persisting soul is what transmigrates.

ANSWER LINE: Immortality means the soul's survival after bodily death, rebirth means karmically conditioned re-becoming, and liberation means release from the cycle of birth and death.